TECH TO THE BOOTH: BJP'S MISSION 51

Aiming at a 51 per cent vote share in 2023, the ruling party in MP has deployed digital technology to micro-manage its booth-level voter outreach

By Rahul Noronha in Bhopal



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WHEN IT COMES TO SETTING targets and working towards them, none does it better than the BJP. The assembly election in Madhya Pradesh may be more than a year and half away, but the state unit is ensuring 2023 is not a repeat of 2018. In that election, the saffron party's 41.02 per cent vote share proved insufficient to make it the largest party in the 230-member assembly. The Congress, with a marginally smaller vote share of 40.89 per cent, bagged 114 seats—five more than the BJP's 109—and went on to form the government. Jyotiraditya Scindia's rebellion in March 2020 and shift to the BJP along with 22 MLAs saw Shivraj Singh Chouhan return as chief minister. Yet, the two-year hiatus after 15 years at the helm put a question mark on the saffron party's electoral dominance in the state. Unwilling to leave anything to chance, the BJP has turned to a booth-based statistical model to increase its vote share by 10 per cent in 2023. Hence Mission 51.

Party leaders know it won't be easy. The plan involves the use of digital technology for sharing data from the booth level—the most crucial unit—to the party headquarters in Bhopal and vice versa. With more than 64,000 polling booths in the state, it is a gargantuan task. Information from the booth is shared via Sangathan, a mobile app developed specifically for the purpose. It is also used to monitor the work of the booth-level team. While workers earlier used to fill in data from their homes, the app's geofencing feature creates a virtual geographic boundary around the booth area and allows data upload only when they are inside it. Updated data can be seen on a dashboard in the tech room at the Bhopal headquarters.

The plan was set in motion in November 2021, with nearly 21,000 *vistarak*s fanning out across the state to set up booth-level bodies. Called 'Tridev' in party parlance, each